Monopoly Auction

Game Design Doc

(Team: Das Capital - Alexis Koss, Stuart Kol, Caleb Anderson, Jeri Huang, Bryn Bills)

Goal

- Create a family-friendly game about competitively accumulating wealth where players invest in assets and negotiate their way to power, driven by both strategy and chance.

Executive Summary

- Deliver the major point of the game structure.
- Introduce the rules, gaming setup, and the main components.
- Bring the Psychographics analysis, targeting the classification of certain players.
- Involve revenue and business analysis in the game product's selling and marketing.

Key Point

- Monopoly (Colors, location), Auction, Property-based,
- Swap, Insurance, Event card deck (Headline, auction property), Jail, Token

How to Play

- Set up the board, all property and headline cards face down.
- Roll the dice to decide who plays first.
- Start money is $20, but the player with 2,3,4,5 places has $21,$22,$23,$24
- Roll the dice to move the token; when landing on any property, auction it; the player with the highest bid wins the property. And put the color token on the properties.
- Each round ends, a headline card will be drawn, and all players follow the instructions.
- Insurance cards are also auctioned and give players a chance to move one more step forward.
- Land on the Swap card will swap 2 cards on the perpendicular sides.

Table of Contents

- 3 - Major points
  - 3 - 1. The Definition of a Monopoly
  - 3 - 2. Blind Auctions
  - 3 - 3. Board Layout and Game Pieces
    - 4 - 3.1 Properties
    - 4 - 3.2 Swapping
    - 5 - 3.3 Insurance
    - 5 - 3.4 Tracking Monopolies and Ownership
    - 5 - 3.5 Headline Deck
    - 5 - 3.6 Auction Deck
  - 6 - 4. Numbers
  - 6 - 5. Income and Starting Money
  - 6 - 6. Movement
  - 6 - 7. Layout of a Player’s Turn
  - 7 - 8. Bankruptcy
  - 7 - 9. Jail
  - 7 - 10. Location Based Monopolies
  - 7 - 11. Ending the Game
  - 8 - 12. Recommended Number of Players
- 9 - Rules
  - 9 - Setup
  - 9 - Objective
  - 10 - Turn Structure
  - 10 - Rounds & Headlines
  - 11 - Bankruptcy
  - 11 - Swap Corners
  - 11 - Insurance Spaces
  - 12 - Miscellaneous Rulings
  - 12 - Monopolies
  - 12 - Ending the Game
  - 12 - Victory Calculation
- 13 - Target Audience & Player Analytics
- 13 - Psychographic Analysis
- 15 - Revenue Model/Business Case
- 16 - Appendices

Major Points

Below you will find the major points that we are proposing to shift for this new version of Monopoly. These points are written in a digestible order for those who are new to **Monopoly Auction**. We highly recommend reading through the below points in the order provided to get a good grasp on **Monopoly Auction**! Please reference the Table of Contents as a quick look-up.

1. The definition of a Monopoly

In the original version of Monopoly, you were considered to have a Monopoly if you had 100% ownership of a color set. With the direction we want to take the game, we are adjusting this definition to now be majority ownership. For example, if there are 5 properties to a color, you would need to own only 3 to have a Monopoly. This is more representative of real life where a Monopoly is not truly *full ownership* of some asset. Instead, it is closer to having enough ownership of an asset or other to have *control* over that asset.

2. Blind Auctions

One of the pain points of the original version of Monopoly is the fact that the person who gets to go first has a massive advantage because, by odds, they will likely be the first around the board and will likely be the only one to freely buy up all properties and not risk paying early rent. Moving to an auction only system gets rid of this advantage because all players can purchase properties at any time.

We decided to proceed with a blind auction system because the new definition of a Monopoly allows them to ebb and flow over the course of the game. You may start with a Monopoly for blue by owning the only 2 blues, but someone could blind bid and win the other 3 blue properties and will have gained control of that Monopoly for the end of the game.

3. Board Layout and Game Pieces

We found the board in the original Monopoly to be a little strange because while the game focuses on accumulation of properties, there are also spaces like Community Chest, Chance, Utilities, etc... that don't feel like rewarding parts of the game. For a majority of cases, it felt like these spaces were never fun to land on. We have redesigned the board to truly focus on what we believe to be core to Monopoly, the properties.

The board is now a 7x7. And contains the following elements:

1. Properties
2. Special spaces (Insurance and Swap)
3. Tracking Monopolies and Ownership
4. Headline Deck
5. Auction Deck

3.1. Properties

A majority of monopolies in the original game were 3 properties with some exceptions at 2. With our new definition of a Monopoly, it is ideal for us to use different numbers of properties. We factored in the following key points

1. Expected number of players (i.e. we want all players to be able to have at least 1 Monopoly)
2. Encourage competition (i.e. when using an even number, it was easy to stalemate a Monopoly)
3. Game length (i.e. larger color sets > harder to get a Monopoly > longer games)

Given these pieces of influence and the evidence we gathered from testing, we have decided to use 5 colors (Blue, Purple, Green, Red, Orange) where each color has 5 properties. At the start of the game, the properties are separated into 5 piles. Each pile should have exactly 1 color from each property. Those piles are then shuffled and each pile is dealt to a part of the board. You will have one extra pile which will form the Auction Deck.

3.2. Swapping

The 1st of the 2 special spaces. 2 of the corners of our board are swap spaces. One of the swap spaces is a place for the player pieces to start at the beginning of the game. When someone lands on a swap space, they can swap a property. Each property must come from a unique side adjacent to the space landed on by the player. For example, if a player landed on the top-left corner of the board and that space is a swap space, they can select 1 property from the top of the board and 1 property from the left of the board and swap them. Pieces on those swapped properties move with them.

3.3. Insurance

The 2nd of the 2 special spaces. 2 of the corners of our board are Insurance spaces. If a player lands on this space, it starts a bid at the base price for Insurance.

3.4. Tracking Monopolies and Ownership

Instead of having a deck of properties for players to hold on to to track ownership of a Monopoly, instead we provide the players tokens. These tokens can be placed onto their properties on the board to indicate ownership. They can also be placed on the Insurance space to represent ownership.

Additionally, there are 5 colored locations in the middle of the board that represent control over a color. Every time a player buys or exchanges ownership of a property, they should reflect that change by moving their tokens in the middle of the board as well. For example, if I bought a blue property, I would put one of my tokens on that blue property and one of my tokens on the blue section in the middle of the board. We introduced this mechanic because it allows a player to easily grasp who has control over what at a simple glance. Each token will have a symbol on it corresponding to the players' piece to tie it to them.

3.5. Headline Deck

Headlines are our version of Chance/Community chest. Instead of occupying a space on the board, these events involve all players and they occur every round (right before the player who went first goes again). We changed the name to Headline because we wanted these to feel more like newspaper headlines as they are likely to involve the group instead of individuals. There are 10 total Headline cards.

Some of these headline cards will have both an effect and will introduce a new non-blind auction. Example: "Buyers Market: Everything is cheap right now! At this time, you may purchase 1 building at half price. You can build without a monopoly with this card (round up to the nearest $1).

Auction one property from the property deck."

One Headline card is drawn and the effect is immediately applied at the end of every round. A round is defined to be ended when all players have taken a turn.

3.6. Auction Deck

The Auction Deck is a set of properties that will be non-blind auctioned at effectively random points in the game. These properties won't exist on the board, but have other uses such as influence for a Monopoly. The auctions from this deck are strictly tied into the Headline Deck.

4. Numbers

Monopoly has quite a big issue with numbers. With the mechanics in the game such as mortgaging selling for half and rents not being clean, it quickly becomes cumbersome to deal with payments. We have reduced the complexity of the numbers to exist in a simpler space. We have also removed the concept of mortgaging properties as this encourages players to trade and make deals with others. A selling of a property to the bank can only occur with a Headline card.

Property	Value/Build Cost	House Rent	Hotel Rent
Purple	1	2	4
Red	2	4	8
Orange	2	4	8
Green	3	6	12
Blue	3	6	12

5. Income and Starting Money

In order to incentivize consistent interaction with auctions, we want our players to have reasonable access to cash. At the start of a players' turn, they gain $1 for every property they own. This does not include Insurance. If a player owns no properties, they collect $0.

Additionally, each player starts with $20. After determining turn order, players that take turns after the first player gain additional funds (2nd gains $1, 3rd gains $2, 4th gains $3, 5th gains $4).

6. Movement

The original version of Monopoly had some special movement rules. Due to our version centering around auctions, the necessity for these features is no longer relevant. Players still roll 2d6 to move. However, doubles do not cause the player to move again and a chain of 3 doubles does not cause the player to go to Jail.

7. Layout of a Player’s Turn

Due to our new systems, we have to put some rules into the order of operations for how a turn is played out. Here is what each player should follow

1. Collect passive income
2. Turn player has an opportunity to build properties or trade
3. Roll 2d6 and move that many spaces.

4. If you land on a special space, take that special action if any. Otherwise, if you land on an unknown property, blind auction with the minimum starting bid of $2. If the property is owned, pay the associated rent.
5. Turn player has another opportunity to trade, **but not to build**

8. Bankruptcy

Bankruptcy is a brutal mechanic in Monopoly and while we don't want to remove the idea completely, we also don't want to unintentionally incentivize players to abuse not being able to pay rent. The only way players lose money is by paying other players or auctioning. You're not allowed to bid more than you own for an auction and if you can't pay the starting bid, your bid is skipped. This means the only way you can go bankrupt is by paying rent.

If you can't pay rent, two things happen

1. The player who would have been paid, collects their rent from the bank
2. You gain a bankrupt note. This will act as a negative modifier at the end of the game, but will not impact your ability to continue to play.

9. Jail

"Jail" and "Go to Jail" are no longer spaces on the board. The only way you go to Jail is through the Headline card. Since we do not have a spot on the board, we actually have a cute little jail cell for your piece! There are a couple notable rules about Jail:

1. A player who has gone to Jail can't go to Jail again for the rest of the game.
2. A player that enters Jail can't do the following until the next Headline card is drawn.
    a. Collect rent
    b. Collect passive income
    c. Participate in auctions
    d. Trade with players
3. Players can't pay nor roll to get out of Jail. They are in Jail for one round.

10. Location Based Monopolies

In addition to color based monopolies, our game also supports location based monopolies. If you have control over a side of the board, this counts as a Monopoly, but only for the purposes of end game scoring. Players can’t build on these monopolies like color monopolies.

11. Ending the Game

The game immediately ends as soon as all properties on the board have been purchased. At this point, each player evaluates their net worth and the person with the largest net worth wins! Below is a guide to follow for calculating net worth:

Calculating Points	Point Values
Per Property	Rent value
Monopolies (Location & Color)	20
Bankruptcy Notes	-5
Cash	Your owned cash

In the unlikely event that not all properties have been purchased, there is a soft limit on game length through the Headline deck. When all cards in the Headline deck run out, instead of drawing a card from the Headline deck, auction off the first unowned property on the board starting from the starting space and moving clockwise around the board. Our ideal target for game length is ~1hr 30min.

12. Recommended Number of Players

Because we want this to be a game targeted to families, we have designed this game with the intended experience of 3-5 players.

Rules

Setup

- There are five colors of properties.
- There are five properties of each color.
    - At the start of the game, put one property of each color into 4 piles (Set the remaining 5 properties off to the side).
    - Shuffle the piles
    - Randomly distribute the piles face down on each side of the board (five on each side).
    - Shuffle remaining 5 properties and place them face down on the “Property” space in the center of the board
- The board is set up so that:
    - There are
        - Five spaces on each side (excluding corners).
        - Two “Insurance” spaces on opposing corners
        - Two “Swap” spaces on on opposing corners
    - There are two decks in the center of the board
        - The “Headline” Deck
        - The “Property” Deck (place remaining property cards on this space)
- Determine Turn order
    - Players roll to determine who goes first.
    - High roll goes first. Play proceeds clockwise around the board.
- Starting cash is based on turn order:
    - First player receives 20
    - Next players receives 21, next player 22 and so on

Objective

The objective of the game is to accumulate the most Wealth.

Wealth is measured in the following ways:

- Owning properties/buildings
- Accumulating money
- Owning Color Monopolies
- Owning Side Monopolies (“Insurance” does not contribute to this)

At the end of the game, the player with the most total wealth wins

Turn Structure

- At the start of your turn, collect your passive income
    - $1 per property you own ("Insurance" does not contribute to this)
- At this point, the player decides if they want to build houses/hotels
    - Only one house/hotel may exist on any space at a time
- The active player rolls 2d6. Move that many spaces
- If you land on an unowned property:
    - An auction begins with the player who landed on the property and rotating clockwise.
    - All auctions are open to everyone.
    - The starting bid:
        - The starting price for every blind property auction begins at $2.
        - Once you pass during an auction, you can no longer bid on that property
    - Auctions may go around the circle of players as much as players are willing to increase the bid price
    - The player with the highest bid acquires the property.
    - The property is then:
        - Flipped over so everyone can see what it is.
        - Two tokens for the player are used
            - One is placed on the property
            - The second is placed on the reflected color in the center of the board
            - These tokens represent ownership.
- If you land on an owned property, pay the value of that properties rent to the player that owns it
    - If you do not have the money to pay the value of rent to the owner, refer to the "Bankruptcy" rules on Page 3

Rounds & Headlines

- Turns continue in the same fashion until a full round is completed.
- A full round means:
    - Every player at the table has rolled to move once.
- When the round returns to the first player and before that player rolls:
    - A Headline card is drawn.
    - The effect of the Headline card happens.
        - Some Headline cards will also say "Auction a property." When this happens
            - The top card is revealed from the property deck in the center of the board
                - All players may auction on the revealed property starting at the value of the property (Ex. $1, $2, or $3)

            - The player to start the auction is the player with the least number of owned properties
                - Tie breaker - least money
                - Double tie breaker - high roll
        - The player with the highest bid acquires the property.
        - Place one chip on the respective color space in the center of the board to represent ownership
    - This property sits in front of the player who wins the auction, does not go on the board and cannot be built on, but may
        - Assist in securing “Monopoly” status and
        - Contributes to your turn based passive income
- The next round then begins.

“Bankruptcy”

Bankruptcy is defined as follows

- If the total amount of available cash you have on hand is not enough to pay rent, you have gone “Bankrupt.”
- In the case of “Bankruptcy,” the following occurs
    - Your available cash is reduced to zero
    - You receive a $-5 debt note from the bank that counts against your total wealth at the end of the game
    - The bank covers the difference between your available cash and what was owed to the other player.
    - You cannot choose to go “Bankrupt.” It must happen from an event in the game

Swap Corners

Two “Swap” corners are found on opposing sides of the board.

- When a player lands on a swap corner they may switch two locations on either side of the corner. Any players on those locations move with them.
    - You cannot swap two spaces from the same side

Insurance Spaces

Two “Insurance” spaces are found on opposing sides of the board.

- Insurance allows a player to add +1 to their die roll at any time of their choosing.
    - This ability cannot be used during the “Reverse” Headline card
- Insurance spaces starting auction price is $1
- Place token on space to represent ownership
- While owned, they cannot be auctioned on

- Once used, they are placed back onto the board and can be purchased again

Miscellaneous Rulings

- Headline Cards
    - “Buyers Market” must be resolved immediately, not over the course of the round
    - “Sellers Market” is the only event in the game that allows a non-player exchange sale of property (i.e. you cannot sell a property to the “bank” once purchased, only trade it to other players)
    - “Property Swap” only applies to spaces on the board, not the ones that were auctioned through the Headline deck
- Trading can only be done by the active player

Monopolies

There are two types of Monopolies

- Color Monopolies
    - The player who owns the majority of any revealed color has a color Monopoly
        - Examples
            - If only one blue space is revealed, the player who owns that blue space has a “Color Monopoly.”
            - If four blue spaces are revealed, one player must own three of them for it to be a “Color Monopoly”
    - Players may build a House and/or Hotels on Properties they have a Color Monopoly on (cost of buildings reflected on properties)
- Side Monopolies
    - A player who owns the most properties on a given side has a side Monopoly.
    - Side monopolies do not affect the ability to build Houses and Hotels
- Both types of monopolies are scored for additional value at the end of the game.

Ending the Game

The game ends at the end of a Round in which all properties have been sold.

If the Headline Deck runs out and some properties have not yet been sold the following occurs:

- If a Headline card cannot be drawn, instead, auction the nearest unsold property from the starting location
- This process continues until properties have been sold.
- Once the final property is sold, the game is over

Victory Calculation

When the game has ended, Count up all your wealth:

- Property = Current cost of rent on the property
    - Ex. One Blue with no buildings is worth 3, a house is 6, and a hotel is 12
- Color Monopoly (majority of a color) = 20
- Location Monopoly (majority on a side) = 20
- Add all remaining money
- Minus the “Bankruptcy” tokens away from your total wealth

The player with the most wealth wins the game.

Target Audience & Player Analytics

Target Audience

This game is designed as a **family-friendly strategy board game**, similar to Monopoly, but with a different win condition. Instead of eliminating players through bankruptcy, players compete to **build monopolies and earn victory points**.

The primary target audience includes:

- **Families and casual players** who enjoy classic board games such as Monopoly, *Ticket to Ride*, or *Catan*.
- **Teenagers and adults (ages 10+)** who enjoy light strategic gameplay.
- **Players who prefer competition without player elimination**, allowing everyone to stay engaged until the end of the game.

Because the game focuses on **points rather than bankruptcy**, it creates a more positive and inclusive experience where players can still compete even if they fall behind economically.

Psychographic Analysis

Rather than targeting players purely by age or demographics, this game focuses on **player motivations and play styles**.

Spike (Killer) -> Mary (Socializer) + Johnny (Explorer)

Monopoly Auction shifts away from classic Monopoly's main Spike (Killer) psychographic and leans more into the Mary (Socializer) and Johnny (Explorer) psychographics. Spike players still get the thrill of outbidding and outmaneuvering opponents, but the game intentionally softens the "destroy everyone else" arc of original Monopoly. These players still can be competitive in the blind auctions and swapping properties without creating runaway leads as they can't eliminate other players.

This game leans more into the Mary (Socializer) motivations because constant auctions, Headline events, and the chaos of Swap keeps everyone talking and reacting together. There are no long stretches of waiting for the game to be over or extremely punishing setbacks, our game encourages shared moments and trading.

Additionally, we also cater to the Johnny (Explorer) psychographic because the board state is unique for every playthrough and unpredictable events reshape the game state. The shifting

property positions with our Swap mechanic create a sense of discovery each time the game is played while evolving monopolies and headline events reward creative problem-solving.

Therefore, players who are likely to enjoy this game typically value:

Strategic Thinking

Many players enjoy planning long-term strategies, such as deciding which properties to collect and when to invest resources.

Friendly Competition

Players want a competitive experience, but one that still feels social and fun for family and friends.

Progress and Achievement

Because the game tracks **victory points**, players constantly feel progress even if they are temporarily behind.

Creative Discovery

Players who enjoy experimenting will like how the board changes state over the course of the game. The Swap, Headline, and shifting monopolies mechanics create a sense of discovery for players who like to explore varying strategies through emerging gameplay moments and clever interactions.

Social Interaction

Like most board games, negotiation, discussion, and shared moments at the table are part of the experience.

Revenue Model/Business Case

Market Pricing

Based on the current board game market, the target retail price is $25 per copy.

This price point positions the game within the mid-range family board game category, comparable to many accessible strategy games sold in major retail stores and online platforms.

Typical examples in this price range include:

- Family strategy board games
- Entry-level hobby games
- Educational or social tabletop games

A $25 price helps make the game affordable for families, while still allowing for reasonable production margins. The game could be distributed through multiple channels:

- Amazon
- Target online store
- Walmart.com

Long-Term Revenue Opportunities

If the game gains traction, additional revenue could come from:

- Expansion packs introducing new properties or mechanics
- Deluxe editions with upgraded components
- Digital adaptations for mobile or tabletop simulator platforms

These options could extend the game's lifecycle and expand its audience.

Appendices

Testing Results

Our team participated in a dozen games of monopoly. Half of those games were down with a near final rules set. In addition, two separate games were played with outside playtest groups. The following is data from these games as they relate to our major game additions and improvements.

All properties are blind auction only

This was of course one of the largest changes made to the game as it received extra focus to ensure it was both fun and balanced. The outside playtesting groups were both focused on this change especially.

All experience from both internal and external playtesting found this a great change. Player interaction and active engagement was greatly improved over the standard game. The endgame state was also much less clear and more competitive as the total strength of each player was not certain until the final cards were revealed.

There was concern that the bid mechanic would slow the game down. However, this did not turn out to be true and in fact the average game was shorter than standard Monopoly (see Pseudo game length limitation).

Win condition that targets a family friendly audience

Playtesting here was focused on making the ending feel far better for every player as opposed to just the winner. Two major points of data come out of the games. The first one was that the ending felt good and players enjoyed the tighter end system of using points instead of waiting for all players to die.

The other feedback was that tracking the state of the game by the end was difficult even for more experienced players. This had us create a tracking system for players to help simplify this process for children and casual players. This helped remove cognitive load from the players without reducing the game's skill.

Pseudo game length limitation

Our first playtest games did not have a way to end apart from the standard Monopoly rules. This left the endgame long and people waiting to lose. To fix this, the event timer was added to provide a guaranteed way for these to draw to a close in a tighter fashion.

Once this was added, all playtest experiences were improved. The average length of the games dropped by around 40 minutes, with around 90 minutes being the new standard. The tighter end state also allowed players to be more competitive with each other. No one player was guaranteed to be dominant in the final turns.

Jail

Early playtesting games removed Jail altogether from Monopoly to streamline the experience. This was seen in games as a net positive, with players no longer wishing to stay in jail to avoid playing the game. However, a desire to have a version of Jail in Monopoly saw the mechanic added to the Event Deck.

The new version that sees one player randomly skip their turn (and have a jail placed on their piece for good fun) was received well. The only change made after the introduction of event jail was to make sure an individual player could not go to jail more than once. This also managed to bring back a version of the get out of jail card.

Numbers

Early playtesting did not target the numbers so these changes arrived later in the process. The first goal was to make the numbers easier to track and use. Both internally and external playtesting supports the success of the simplified game numbers. It was much easier for people to know at a glance how much something cost. A quick reference sheet was provided that also helped ensure that the numbers of the game did not get in the way of the fun.

The Second goal was to ensure the numbers allowed for a better shift between early and late game scaling over standard Monopoly. Early games showed that while better the Rent values still scaled too fast, kicking people out of the game and preventing some from being competitive in the final turns. The numbers were thus again adjusted to ensure all players can be competitive in the late game. These tweaks succeeded in making sure consistently three or more players were all in the running to win in the final rounds.